

# Operational AI adoption pathways

PRIVATE CANDIDATE - OWNER REVIEW

This report maps four distinct operational choices visible in the published survey: integration, automated decisions, in-house development or training, and governance.

## Key descriptive pattern

**Among AI-using SMEs, system integration and policy/guidance have higher point estimates than automated decision-making. In-house AI development or training is less common when measured across all businesses.**

### INTEGRATE

AI users

Connect AI tools to business systems

### AUTOMATE

AI users

Use automated decision-making systems

### BUILD

All businesses

Use data to develop or train AI

### GOVERN

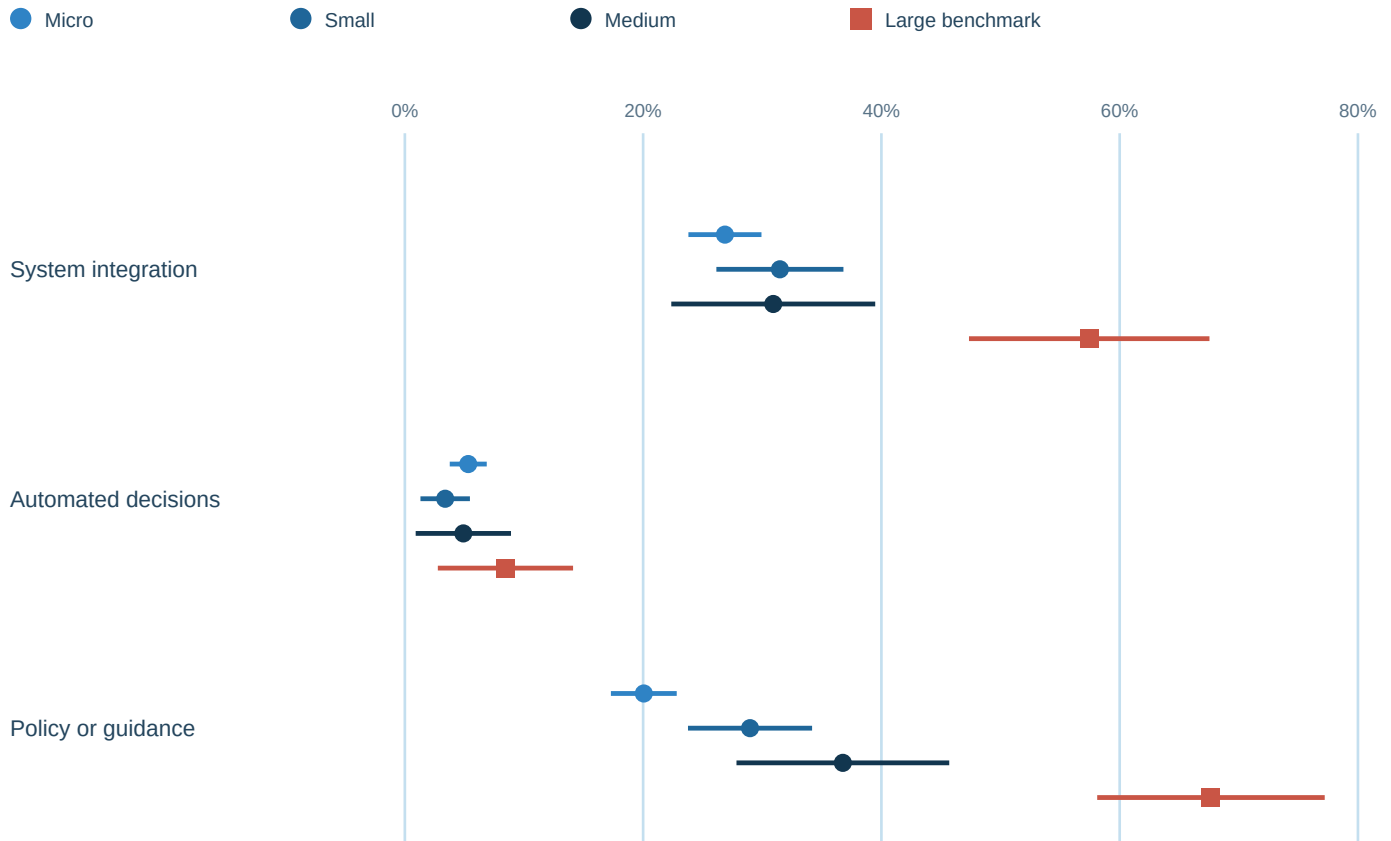
AI users

Put policy or guidance in place

**Denominator rule: integration, automated decisions and governance describe businesses already using AI. Development/training describes all businesses. The measures are shown separately and are not combined into a score.**

## Operational pathways among AI users

Three indicators with the same conditional denominator: UK businesses that use AI technologies. Point estimates include supplied 95% intervals.



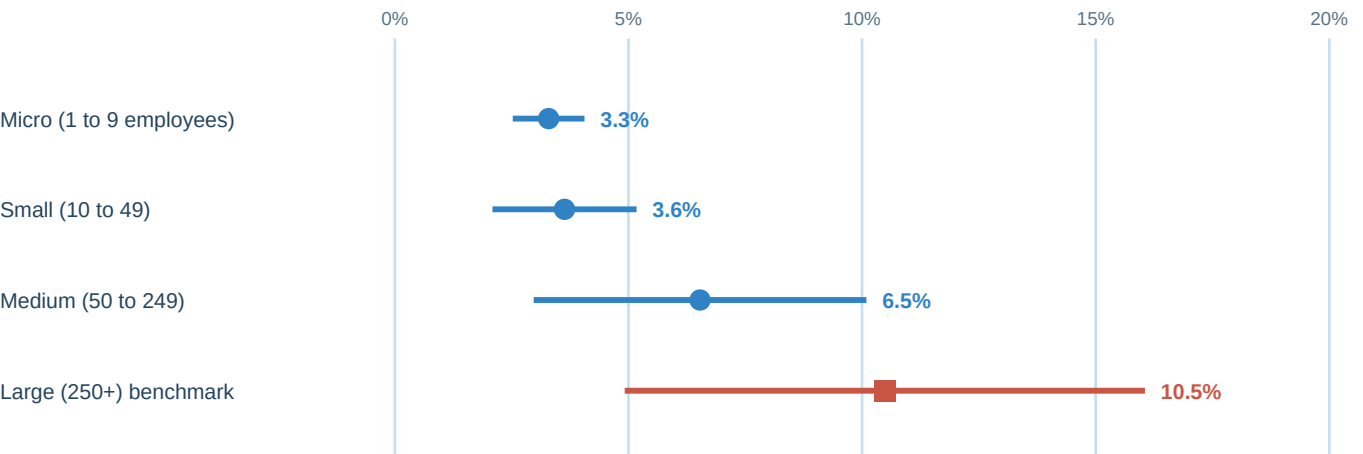
### Point estimates

| Indicator           | Micro | Small | Medium | Large* |
|---------------------|-------|-------|--------|--------|
| System integration  | 26.9% | 31.5% | 30.9%  | 57.4%  |
| Automated decisions | 5.3%  | 3.4%  | 4.9%   | 8.4%   |
| Policy or guidance  | 20.1% | 29.0% | 36.8%  | 67.7%  |

\*Large is a benchmark. The chart retains the full supplied intervals. No pairwise significance test is claimed.

# In-house AI development or training

Percentage of all UK businesses using data to develop, train or improve AI, including machine-learning models or generative AI.



The point estimate is 3.3% for micro, 3.6% for small, 6.5% for medium and 10.5% for the large-business benchmark. This all-business measure must not be compared arithmetically with the AI-user indicators.

## Exact values and rounded respondent bases

| Size group               | Estimate | 95% interval | Base  | Role      |
|--------------------------|----------|--------------|-------|-----------|
| Micro (1 to 9 employees) | 3.3%     | 2.5-4.1%     | 2,500 | SME       |
| Small (10 to 49)         | 3.6%     | 2.1-5.2%     | 680   | SME       |
| Medium (50 to 249)       | 6.5%     | 3.0-10.1%    | 220   | SME       |
| Large (250+) benchmark   | 10.5%    | 4.9-16.1%    | 130   | Benchmark |

Rounded unweighted bases are survey respondents, not numbers of UK businesses.

## A framework, not a maturity ladder

### Why these are pathways

Businesses may adopt AI through task-focused tools, system integration, automated decisions, in-house development or formal governance. The survey does not establish a single required order.

### What the evidence supports

The point estimates provide a general business-size baseline. They can later support separate pathway reports and cautious sector cuts where the sample and suppression rules permit.

### What the evidence does not support

No readiness score, maturity score or causal sequence is calculated. The report does not measure effectiveness, return on investment or whether integration, automation, development or governance is appropriate for an individual business.

### Evidence trail

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026, Tables 43, 47, 48 and 50. Fieldwork: 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Central estimates, supplied 95% confidence limits and rounded unweighted bases are retained.

**Review boundary: candidate F-005 remains private until the complete five-report and website review is accepted.**